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We had assumed last year that inkjet MFDs would soon be on their way out in the face of the falling prices of laser devices; turns out this wasn't to be. In fact, the market teems with as many inkjet devices as it did a year ago. Inkjet printers still rule the photo-printing roost: laser printers can only dream of coming even close.

For our test, we divided the contenders into Home, Office, and Professional, based on their price and the features they offer.

HOME MFDs

"MFDs are not really meant for home use": that's what you're told. But with prices rivalling those of inkjet printers, we do see MFDs making their way into homes.

The MFDs in this first category cost below Rs 6,000, and lack features such as fax, since this is not of much importance to home users. We selected five MFDs here—from Brother (the DCP-130C), Canon (the PIXMA MP160), Lexmark (the X1270), and two from HP (the Deskjet F380 and the Photosmart C3188).

Features Printing

An MFD's primary and most important function is printing. The Brother MFD uses piezoelectric technology to fire ink drops onto the paper surface, as against the thermal technology employed by Canon, HP, and Lexmark.

The Brother and Canon MFDs come with four separate ink cartridges—one each for black, cyan, magenta, and yellow. This is economical if you end up emptying the tank of one colour. With a two-cartridge system (one black and one for all three colours), you'll have to replace the one colour cartridge even if the other colours haven't been spent.

Barring the Canon PIXMA MP160, which has an input tray paper capacity of just 20 sheets, the other MFDs accommodate 100. Though this is not very important for home use, a higher capacity certainly doesn't hurt.

Scan, Copy, Fax

All the MFDs feature 48-bit flatbed scanners capable of scanning A4 size documents. A scanning resolution of 600 x 1200 is the most common, but the HP MFDs have better resolutions of 600 x 2400 and 1200 x 2400—the Deskjet F380 and the Photosmart C3188 respectively.

You can scan directly to a destination on your PC—like an e-mail or image management application—from the Brother DCP-130C and Lexmark X1270, something the rest of the MFDs in this category can't. These two devices also come with image editing and OCR software.



Canon PIXMA MP160
Performance plus good value

Copying is a breeze with all the MFDs supporting colour as well as black-and-white copying. Except for the Lexmark, all the MFDs support multi-copying. The Brother DCP-130C supports 99 copies in this mode, the highest among the MFDs across all categories.

Fax and Automatic Document Feeding (ADF) are absent on all the MFDs, but they will not be missed much.

Build Quality And Other Features

The Canon MP160 has a delicate scanner lid, which therefore seems easily susceptible to damage. The Lexmark didn't seem too sturdy either, but the scanner lid is a tad better than the Canon's. The Brother and HP have commendable build quality. It is relieving that none of the MFDs have trays sticking out, so there's no possibility of breaking one.

The Brother DCP-130C has the smallest footprint and is very compact, but is still the heaviest.

While the HP F380 and the Lexmark do not feature any LCD interface, the Canon MP160 has a

7-segment display—something is better than nothing! The Brother has a one-line LCD display that provides you with all the necessary information, while the HP Photosmart C3188 has an icon-based display, also very easy to understand.

The Brother DCP-130C comes loaded with media features such as support for a variety of memory cards and PictBridge. The HP Photosmart C3188, being a proper photo MFD, has buttons to reprint photos as well as proof sheets. Interestingly, it features memory card slots but not PictBridge!

Performance Printing

The Canon PIXMA MP160 prints really fast—our normal-quality text document printed in 9.3 seconds flat. It was also the fastest in printing our combi-document at normal quality. Even while printing at the highest speeds, it prints exceptionally well. The edges of the text are crisp, and the ink doesn't blot the paper even at high quality.

When printing at the best quality, the HP F380 and Lexmark are the slowest. The Lexmark is the slowest at photo printing as well. The Canon MP160 and HP C3188 have excellent photo print quality, but the Brother produced a print that looked faded—its "photo MFD" title doesn't reflect in its quality.

Scanning And Copying

While 200 dpi black-and-white scan times is around the same for all the devices, the difference becomes more evident at higher resolutions and in full colour. The Lexmark slows down the most in this case, while the Canon is the least affected.

The scans produced by both



HP Photosmart C3188 All-in-One
A value photo MFD with good features